3.2 Forming Alliances

Have you ever heard the phrase "strength in numbers"? In the 1600s, as Native Americans and Europeans battled with each other in the Middle Colonies, they discovered that it's sometimes better to be part of a larger group than to stand alone.

MAIN IDEA The Iroquois Confederacy consisted of five tribes that worked together to defeat other Native American tribes and the French.

CLASHES AMONG CULTURES

As white colonists continued moving into New England and the Middle Colonies, two groups of Native Americans began to feel increasingly threatened by their presence.

One group that banded together was the Algonquian (al-GAHN-kwee-uhn). It consisted of the tribes who lived along the Atlantic coast and spoke similar languages. The Pequot tribe resided in New England. The Lenape inhabited the region that became the Middle Colonies. The Algonquian were hunters and gatherers. While they also fished and planted crops, they moved each season to follow the supply of food and lived in temporary camps while away from their villages.

Historically, the Algonquian were the enemies of another united group of tribes, the Iroquois (IHR-uh-kwoy). The Iroquois lived in what is currently central New York State. The French gave these Native Americans the name *Iroquois*, but they called themselves the Haudenosaunee (hah-duh-NAH-suh-nee), or "People of the Longhouse," for the style of home that they built and lived in with their families.



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Wampum Accessory
Wampum are white and purple beads made from the shells of a certain clam and sea snail. Native Americans made woven items from strings of wampum. The decorations recorded information and sometimes confirmed authority of the wearer.

The arrival of colonists from Europe added another source of tension to the region. Yet another wave of settlers was now occupying disputed tribal territories, disrupting hunting grounds, communities, and sacred sites.

UNITED WE STAND

Even before Europeans began colonizing and claiming land in North America, conflicts among groups of Native Americans led some of them to form **alliances**, or agreements, with one another. One of the most important alliances was the **Iroquois Confederacy**. A **confederacy** is an agreement among several groups to protect and support one another in battle or other endeavors. In about 1600, the Iroquois Confederacy joined together five tribes: the Mohawk, Onondaga, Oneida, Cayuga, and Seneca, ending the fighting that had once raged among them. The addition of the Tuscarora about 120 years later would change the confederacy's name to the Six Nations.

By banding together, Native Americans hoped to protect their lands and culture and prevent further strife, but they also formed alliances with the French and British. These alliances shifted over time. Sometimes Native Americans even pitted the French, British, and colonists from other countries against one another.

The Iroquois—the Mohawk, in particular—often traded furs with Dutch and British settlers in exchange for firearms. In this way, the trading partners came to rely on each other, and they supported each other in battle. Likewise, the Lenape and the Huron, both enemies of the Iroquois, allied with the French.

Battles between the French and Iroquois over control of the fur trade continued. Due to high demand for their fur, beavers became scarce in the East by the mid-1600s. As a result, the Iroquois Confederacy moved west to gain greater access to beavers in the region, warring with competing tribes along the way. The Iroquois also attacked New France in the North, hoping to end French fur trading in the Ohio Valley and beyond.

In 1689, the Iroquois attacked the settlement of Lachine, near Montreal, in present-day Canada. The attack was in response to a raid two years earlier in which the French had destroyed Iroquois corn. The Iroquois killed about 250 settlers and burned the settlement. More back-and-forth retaliation followed until both sides grew weary of conflict. The weakened Iroquois made peace and, in 1701, signed a treaty of **neutrality**, in which they agreed not to take sides in future wars. But the conflict over land and furs was to grow even more.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did forming alliances help the members of the Iroquois Confederacy?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** In what ways did the demand for beaver fur affect alliances among Native Americans and Europeans?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** How does the map help you understand why some Native Americans living near the Great Lakes might have been easy targets for the Iroquois Confederacy?

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